



BOEING SUPERSONIC

The Boeing SST was conceived in the 1960s, when funding was readily available for prestige projects that promised to push technology to new limits. Immensely ambitious, the SST was originally planned to fly at three times the speed of sound with 200 passengers on board.

But these technical setbacks were a relatively minor matter compared with the political storm that now confronted all the SSTs. No one in the aircraft industry had foreseen the scale of popular opposition that now awaited any innovation that would increase noise and pollution. When the first turbojets entered the scene in the 1950s, New York noise regulations were changed to accommodate them. But by the late 1960s, times were changing. There was no way that the engines required for supersonic flight could avoid being loud on take-off and landing. They would also inevitably drag a sonic boom along their supersonic flight path. And the newly ascendant ecology movement claimed they would damage the ozone layer.

Shattered dreams

By 1971 the US economy was in trouble and prestigious high-tech projects out of favor. Badgered by residents groups from airport districts and by the ecology movement, US Congress withdrew funding from the Boeing SST. With the American authorities no longer having any interest in promoting supersonic flight, Concorde faced an uphill struggle against protesters. A further blow came with the tripling of oil prices in 1973–74, which fatally undermined any prospect of operating fleets of fuel-guzzling SSTs as an economic proposition.

The Tu-144 project suffered a shattering setback at the Paris Air Show in June 1973, when one of the Tupolev SSTs disintegrated pulling out of a steep dive. The Soviets nonetheless pressed ahead with production and the aircraft entered service with Aeroflot in 1975, initially flying cargo. It proved uneconomical and impractical to operate. After another Tu-144 crashed in May 1978, production was halted and the attempt at supersonic services discontinued.

Concorde was far more successful. It went into service with British Airways and Air France in 1976 and, after a stiff fight, won the prized access to New York. Concorde cut the transatlantic journey time to three and a half hours, but it could only operate at a profit by charging an astonishing price for a ticket—\$9,000 (£6,000) return by 2000. Concorde had become a prestigious curio, an elegant relic of a lost dream of supersonic passenger flight, long before commercial services ended on October 24, 2003.

ILL-FATED SOVIET SST

The Soviet Tupolev Tu-144 was the first supersonic airliner to fly, beating Concorde by two months. The Tu-144 program suffered a severe setback when one disintegrated in the air at the 1973 Paris Air Show. In operation, it suffered similar problems to Concorde, including uneconomically high fuel consumption.

CONCORDE CRASHES

Concorde had an impeccable safety record until July 25, 2000, when one of Air France's fleet crashed after take-off from Charles de Gaulle airport, Paris, killing 109 passengers and crew. All Concordes were grounded. It was later established that one of the airliner's tires had hit a strip of metal on the runway, shredding off rubber that struck fuel tanks in the bottom of the wing; kerosene poured out of a hole and caught fire. The Concordes returned to the air in 2001, with modifications that included lining some fuel tanks with Kevlar, the material used in bulletproof vests. But in spite of these improvements, three years after the crash, all Concordes were retired from service.

CONCORDE IN FLAMES

The pilot of the Air France Concorde tried to nurse his aircraft as far as another Paris airport but the intensity of the fire gave him no chance.

